

Digital Impact

BY THE DIGITAL CITIZENSHIP AMBASSADORS

Arda Ünal

Writer & Digital Citizenship Ambassador

Number 4 | March 2026

Istanbul

SEV American College

Contents

From The Editor

The Loneliest Generation: How Screens Replaced Conversations

Your Brain on Notifications: The Psychology of Always Being "On"

Lost in Translation: What We Lose When We Text Instead of Talk

Works Cited

From The Editor

We live in a world where you can talk to someone on the other side of the planet in half a second, but you might not know what your neighbour had for dinner. We've got more ways to communicate than any generation before us — and somehow, a lot of us feel more alone than ever. That paradox is what this issue is about.

I'm not here to tell you to throw your phone in the sea. That would be hypocritical — I'm typing this on a laptop, and I'll probably check my notifications three times before I finish this paragraph. But I do think we owe it to ourselves to understand what these tools are doing to our heads and to the way we relate to each other. Not because technology is evil, but because understanding something is the first step to using it well.

In this issue, we'll look at three angles: how digital life is reshaping our sense of connection, what constant notifications are doing to our psychology, and what gets lost when a conversation turns into a text thread. Some of it might make you uncomfortable. Good. That's kind of the point.

I hope you'll read this with an open mind — and maybe, afterwards, put your phone down for ten minutes and talk to someone face to face. You might be surprised how good it feels.

Arda Ünal

Digital Citizenship Ambassador

The Loneliest Generation:

How Screens Replaced Conversations

Here's something that doesn't make sense at first: we're more connected than any humans in history, and loneliness rates are at an all-time high. The U.S. Surgeon General declared loneliness an epidemic in 2023, comparing its health effects to smoking 15 cigarettes a day. [1] That's not a metaphor someone made up to scare you — that's a medical comparison backed by peer-reviewed research.

So what's going on? If I can video-call my friend in Tokyo at 3 a.m. and send memes to a group chat of forty people, why do so many of us still feel isolated? The answer, I think, is that connection and communication aren't the same thing. We've got plenty of communication — notifications, DMs, stories, reactions. But genuine connection — the kind where someone actually sees you, not just your curated online version — that's getting rarer.

The Substitution Effect

Researchers at the University of Pennsylvania found that limiting social media use to 30 minutes a day led to significant reductions in loneliness and depression. [2] Think about what that implies: the thing we use to feel less alone is actually making us more alone. It's like drinking salt water when you're thirsty — it feels like it should help, but it makes the problem worse.

The reason is what psychologists call the 'substitution effect.' Every minute spent scrolling through Instagram is a minute not spent having a real conversation, making eye contact, reading someone's body language, or just sitting in comfortable silence with another person. Digital interaction substitutes for analogue connection, but it doesn't replace it. Your brain knows the difference, even if you don't.

The Comparison Trap

Social media doesn't just steal time from real relationships — it actively poisons how we feel about ourselves. A study published in the Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology found a direct causal link between social media use and decreased well-being, driven primarily by social comparison. [2] You're not just looking at photos of someone's holiday — you're unconsciously measuring your life against a highlight reel that doesn't represent reality.

And here's the cruel irony: the people posting those perfect lives often feel just as inadequate as the people watching them. Everyone's performing for an audience, and nobody's actually living. It's a theatre where the actors and the audience are equally miserable.

The fix isn't to delete all your apps — it's to recognise what's happening. Awareness is the antidote. When you catch yourself comparing your behind-the-scenes to someone else's highlight reel, that moment of recognition is enough to break the cycle. At least for a little while.

[1] Murthy, V. (2023). "Our Epidemic of Loneliness and Isolation." U.S. Surgeon General Advisory. hhs.gov/surgeongeneral/priorities/connection/

[2] Hunt, M.G., et al. (2018). "No More FOMO: Limiting Social Media Decreases Loneliness and Depression." *Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology*, 37(10), 751-768.

Arda Ünal

Digital Citizenship Ambassador

Your Brain on Notifications:

The Psychology of Always Being "On"

The average smartphone user receives between 80 and 100 notifications per day. [3] Each one triggers a tiny hit of dopamine — the same neurotransmitter involved in gambling, sugar, and cocaine. I'm not saying checking your phone is the same as using drugs. But I am saying that the neurochemistry is uncomfortably similar.

What notifications really do is keep your brain in a state of constant low-level alertness. You're never fully relaxed, never fully focused, because some part of you is always waiting for the next ping. Psychologists call this 'continuous partial attention' — and it's destroying our ability to think deeply. [4]

The Attention Residue Problem

Here's something most people don't know: when you switch tasks — say, from writing an essay to checking a notification — your brain doesn't fully switch. Part of your attention stays stuck on the previous task. Professor Sophie Leroy at the University of Washington calls this 'attention residue,' and her research shows that it significantly reduces performance on whatever you do next. [4]

In practical terms, this means that every time you glance at your phone during homework, you're not just losing the three seconds it takes to read the notification. You're losing ten to fifteen minutes of cognitive performance because your brain can't fully re-engage with the original task. Multiply that by the dozens of notifications you get daily, and you start to understand why so many students feel like they can't concentrate anymore. It's not that our brains are broken — it's that we're asking them to do something they weren't designed to do.

The Anxiety Loop

Notifications don't just fragment our attention — they create anxiety. A study by the American Psychological Association found that 'constant checkers' — people who continuously check their phones — reported significantly higher stress levels than those who didn't. [5] And the relationship is bidirectional: stress makes you check your phone more, and checking your phone makes you more stressed. It's a feedback loop with no natural exit.

The solution that most experts recommend isn't dramatic — it's surprisingly simple. Turn off non-essential notifications. Put your phone in another room when you're studying. Set specific times to check messages instead of responding in real-time. These aren't revolutionary

ideas, but the research consistently shows that they work. The hard part isn't knowing what to do — it's actually doing it.

[3] Zippia Research. (2023). "Average Number of Push Notifications Sent Per Day." zipppia.com/advice/push-notification-statistics/

[4] Leroy, S. (2009). "Why Is It So Hard to Do My Work? The Challenge of Attention Residue When Switching Between Work Tasks." *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, 109(2), 168-181.

[5] American Psychological Association. (2017). "Stress in America: Coping with Change." APA Stress Report. apa.org/news/press/releases/stress/

Arda Ünal

Digital Citizenship Ambassador

Lost in Translation:

What We Lose When We Text Instead of Talk

Albert Mehrabian's famous communication model — often misquoted, but still useful — suggests that only 7% of emotional meaning comes from words. The rest comes from tone of voice (38%) and body language (55%). [6] When you send a text, you're transmitting 7% of what you actually mean. The other 93% is left for the reader to guess. And guess what? They usually guess wrong.

We've all been there. You send a perfectly normal message, and the other person reads it as cold, sarcastic, or angry. Or you receive a 'fine.' and spend twenty minutes trying to figure out whether they're actually fine or furious. This isn't a bug in human nature — it's what happens when you strip communication down to raw text and expect it to carry the same emotional weight as a face-to-face conversation.

The Empathy Deficit

MIT professor Sherry Turkle, who's spent thirty years studying how technology affects relationships, argues that we're experiencing a 'flight from conversation.' In her research, she found that college students' capacity for empathy has dropped by 40% compared to students twenty years ago — and the decline accelerated with the rise of smartphones. [7]

The connection isn't hard to understand. Empathy is a skill, and like any skill, it requires practice. You develop empathy by watching someone's face when they're sad, hearing the tremor in their voice when they're nervous, noticing when someone's smile doesn't reach their eyes. None of that translates to a text message. When we replace conversations with texts, we're not just choosing a different medium — we're choosing to practice a fundamentally different skill. And the skill we're practising doesn't build empathy.

The Illusion of Connection

Here's what worries me most: many of us have convinced ourselves that digital communication is equivalent to real communication. We maintain 'friendships' through occasional likes and birthday messages. We feel 'close' to people we haven't spoken to in months. We have hundreds of followers and three people we could actually call at midnight if something went wrong.

Turkle puts it perfectly: 'We expect more from technology and less from each other.' [7] We've lowered the bar for what counts as a relationship, and the result is that many of our 'connections' are a mile wide and an inch deep.

I'm not saying we should stop texting. Texting is useful, it's convenient, and sometimes it's the right tool. But it shouldn't be the only tool. If the most meaningful conversation you've had this week was a text thread, that might be worth thinking about. Not with guilt — just with awareness. And maybe with a phone call to someone you haven't heard from in a while.

[6] Mehrabian, A. (1971). *Silent Messages: Implicit Communication of Emotions and Attitudes*. Wadsworth Publishing.

[7] Turkle, S. (2015). *Reclaiming Conversation: The Power of Talk in a Digital Age*. Penguin Press.

Arda Ünal

Digital Citizenship Ambassador

Works Cited

Murthy, V. (2023). "Our Epidemic of Loneliness and Isolation." U.S. Surgeon General Advisory.
<https://www.hhs.gov/surgeongeneral/priorities/connection/>

Hunt, M.G., Marx, R., Lipson, C., & Young, J. (2018). "No More FOMO: Limiting Social Media Decreases Loneliness and Depression." *Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology*, 37(10), 751-768.

Zipppia Research. (2023). "Average Number of Push Notifications Sent Per Day."
<https://www.zipppia.com/advice/push-notification-statistics/>

Leroy, S. (2009). "Why Is It So Hard to Do My Work? The Challenge of Attention Residue When Switching Between Work Tasks." *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*, 109(2), 168-181.

American Psychological Association. (2017). "Stress in America: Coping with Change." APA Stress Report.
<https://www.apa.org/news/press/releases/stress/>

Mehrabian, A. (1971). *Silent Messages: Implicit Communication of Emotions and Attitudes*. Wadsworth Publishing.

Turkle, S. (2015). *Reclaiming Conversation: The Power of Talk in a Digital Age*. Penguin Press.